



THIIIRD



Image by Silvia Draz / Thiiirdmagazine.co.uk

Component 2, Section C: Media in the Online Age

Focus areas:

- ♦ Media language
- ♦ Representation
- ♦ Media industries
- ♦ Media audiences
- ♦ Media contexts

Product context

THIIIRD is an independent fashion, arts and culture magazine, available in print and online, with its own podcast and seasonal events series. It offers an inclusive

platform for those social groups that tend to be overlooked by the mainstream media. THIIIRD's strapline describes it as an **'Intersectional magazine celebrating culture, diversity and heritage – KEEP YOUR THIRD EYE OPEN.'** Foregrounding the principle that the personal is political, THIIIRD is an activist fashion magazine that offers a safe space for creative people from marginalised groups to take the stage, showcase their work and to discuss issues that matter to them in their own terms.

*'On glossy mag pages, over the radio and through events, we centralise the thought, being and art of people of colour, queer, trans and non-binary people and others with underrepresented backgrounds.'*¹

Rhona Ezuma, the editor-in-chief, founded the magazine in 2017. Rhona is of Black British Nigerian heritage and was born and brought up in London. After graduating from The University of Manchester with a degree in English, she worked in mainstream publishing as a journalist, fashion stylist and costume designer, where she realised that many social groups were left out.

THIIIRD exists not just to counter the narrow beauty ideals of white dominated mainstream magazine culture, with its tokenistic nods to race and class in its workforce, but to provide new opportunities and act as a hub for a community of artists and activists to bring about social change for the future.

THIIIRD is informed by critical theory and explicitly defines its uniqueness in the magazine marketplace by implicit reference to the ideas of Paul Gilroy and bell hooks. As stated in their manifesto: *'The ethos*

¹ <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/about>



of THIIIRD is informed by decolonial and intersectional feminist thought. We believe in the potential of print and multimedia as a tool for (self-) affirmation and positive social change.’² THIIIRD understands that the overlapping intersection of belonging to several minority groups at once exacerbates marginalisation, so they prioritise and amplify those voices. By offering a broadly inclusive platform to all those groups seen as minority by the mainstream, they could attract a very wide and diverse community of participant readers.

The triple i’s in THIIIRD’s title refer to three ideas:

- *third space theory*, the meeting point between marginalised and dominant cultures; there is a dynamic interchange of ideas where new cultural identities are formed.
- *third kid culture*, the children of parents from another culture. The first is the parents’ own culture, the second is the culture of the environment where their children are raised, and the third is the unique, individual experience of those children as they assimilate both the culture of their family’s background and their own surroundings.
- *the third eye*, which refers to the idea of an inner eye in Hinduism that connects to a higher consciousness: a more spiritual, enlightened perception than ordinary eyesight.

The annual glossy print magazine is of high quality and is made for a long read, for inspiration and for collecting. Each issue has a unifying theme, such as Journeys or Defiant Beauty. The #6 ‘BODY MOVEMENTS’ edition (published at the time of the FIFA World Cup in Qatar) discusses how sports can be divisive, discriminatory, sexist, racist, transphobic and homophobic; and how

sporting bodies need to work on widening participation for everyone. In the editor’s letter, Rhona writes ‘Sport, as it currently exists, is not a safe place for all, but our belief is that it could be. In this issue, it is our hope that we have begun to chip away at some of the issues that create barriers within this sphere.’³

The website publishes some of the same articles as the print edition; some are extracts, and some are different, more contemporary ones too, that may combine with the promotion of specific cultural events. The web magazine doesn’t have the same features and formal principles as the print magazine but has the same house style and beautiful quality of design. You can access many articles for free in the archive.

THIIIRD Waves is their podcast that draws in other audiences. ‘Exploring the intersections between culture and activism, **THIIIRD Waves** spotlights guests whose expertise and lived experience provide insights on topical issues through the lens of representation, access and privilege. The show is hosted by the women of THIIIRD magazine - producer Daniela Hornskov Sun, DJ Tryb, and founder Rhona Ezuma who bring to the table perspectives from their Danish Chinese and Black British Nigerian backgrounds.’⁴ Initially, the podcast was produced bi-monthly in collaboration with Soho Radio. Since the pandemic, the team have found it more manageable to produce podcasts in a series of six episodes.

The editorial board is a small team of passionate individuals, who devote their time and their talents to create THIIIRD out of a drive for creativity and their community. At present, most work is on a voluntary or freelance basis, with a few employees managing the weekly office administration. Rhona’s work as editor-in-chief is often voluntary and has to be done alongside her day job as a fashion magazine and film stylist. Any profits THIIIRD makes get reinvested into the magazine.

² THIIIRD Manifesto <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/about>

³ Rhona Ezuma, Editor’s letter, Why the sports theme, why body movements? p5 Thiiird, Issue #6 October 2022

⁴ <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/podcast>



PART 1 STARTING POINTS: Media language

The codes and conventions of media forms and products, including the processes through which media language develops as genre.

THIIIRD has a distinctive house style consistent across both print and digital magazines. The minimalist, modern layout of vibrant colours with limited text foregrounds the stories behind the striking photographic images and the branding of the title. The scrolling images are all portraits of people of colour, fashion images or shots of the print front cover. The serene purple background of the website's home page contrasts with the simple white lettering of the masthead across the top and the strapline that scrolls along the foot of the first screen – AMPLIFYING UNDERREPRESENTED VOICES – which anchors the meaning behind the selection of images. (See here:

[Thiird \(thiirdmagazine.co.uk\)](http://thiirdmagazine.co.uk)

Strong blocks of colour opposites, such as orange or fresh green against the purple, contrast to highlight the contextual information of the website. It also draws attention to its statement of values, the manifesto and the images of the editorial team, their names and roles. It is clear that all are of mixed cultural heritage or people of colour, and predominantly women. They all have @ links to their Instagram accounts, inviting us to find out more and participate in the THIIIRD community, and possibly collaborate with the project.

The masthead is classical in design, in simple, sans serif uppercase lettering. This gives the brand a sense of authority and confidence. The quirky design of the three pillars in the centre gives it a unique identity, making it instantly recognisable as a logo. The design of the III in Roman numerals connotes classical architecture, like the pillars of the Parthenon in Athens – respectable, important, the home of democracy. At the same time, they reflect the triple meaning of

the title, reinforcing the idea of the third space theory, third kid culture and the third eye. This design gives the magazine a distinct brand identity for the community of readers it is aimed towards.

THIIIRD

[Image by Thiirdmagazine.co.uk](http://thiirdmagazine.co.uk)

The wide-ranging bank of stories are neatly laid out against a white background, leading with a strong, enigmatic and colourful image and a short caption title, which positions us to be intrigued and want to find out more. For example, Swim Dem Crew shows two bearded men smiling, in orange and green swimming hats; Skater UKTIS, the group of Muslim women redefining skater culture; the Let's Let Black Boys SMILE project; an interview with Munroe Bergdorf and many more.

How the combination of elements of media language influence meaning.

The first image you see on the website is a low angled MCU shot looking up at a regal looking, young Black model wearing a 1950s vintage pillbox hat with a veil. The hat has been customised with diamante beads and a red chiffon scarf to resemble a head-dress. The cultural connotations of the image are richly multifaceted and different audiences will bring their own cultural competences to read these dress codes in different ways. Her purple eyeshadow links with the brand colour of the background of the homepage, and the red of her top and scarf link with colour blocks on the rest of the page and with the menu bar, creating a unified design. She appears to be an iconic model for THIIIRD, and her style is idiosyncratic, confident and powerful. This image is juxtaposed by a highly stylised soft-coloured image of two women with ornately braided hair, their heart shaped embrace and gaze towards the viewer draw you in to another intriguing narrative.



Image by Silvia Draz / Thiiirdmagazine.co.uk

Caption: 'Water No Get Enemy', Defiant Beauty, 2021

The way media language incorporates viewpoints and ideologies.

On closer inspection, there are several other referential codes that some readers may pick up on more than others. Her head-dress is given extra height and importance by being wrapped around what looks like a book, but is in fact a packet of Africa's Finest Plantain Fufu. Some will recognise a playful stylised, postmodern reference to a common ingredient in some kitchens, that is perhaps a closed cultural reference. The logo on her top is for the Chinese fashion brand UOOYAA. It is not clear whether either of these are sponsored content or just props; but elsewhere in THIIIRD, there is an article about the ideology of the UOOYAA brand:

*'UOOYAA (pronounced as "ow-ya") made its debut in the fashion industry in 2014 as a size-friendly fashion brand that doesn't sit well with what Chinese mainstream media and beauty ideals stand for. The name itself was born out of the willingness to break apart from a white-centric idealisation of beauty, typical of China, that idolises white western women.'*⁵

It is clear that these references chime with THIIIRD'S overarching message of mixed cultural heritages intersecting in a new third space. This young black model is therefore a figure to be admired, respected and looked up to.

You could select your own images and see what meanings resonate with your own

cultural experiences, and investigate if there are any further references signifying alternative layers of meaning.

Theoretical perspectives

Theoretical approaches to postmodernism – Jean Baudrillard

THIIIRD can be seen as a postmodern magazine in as much as it is a bricolage of voices, perspectives and multicultural references, all colliding with each other in a bright and colourful, polysemic landscape. Jean Baudrillard argues that in a postmodern age, we are immersed in a world of simulacra where images no longer refer to anything 'real'. However, THIIIRD does the opposite. Rather, it wants to shine a spotlight on the validity of every contributor's real lived experience, and to champion their reality, rarely seen in mainstream media. THIIIRD's production team are presented as trustworthy people we can relate to, because they are just like us. The contributors' stories are authentic, whether they are an Olympic champion or a horse rider at stables in a South London housing estate. Their costume may be stylised as a fantasy element of their reality, but they are presented as admirable people in a very real, down to earth location.

PART 2 STARTING POINTS: Representation

The way events, issues, individuals (including self-representation) and social groups (including social identity) are represented through processes of selection and combination.

THIIIRD's primary subject matter is to discuss issues of representation. Their purpose is to shine a light on and amplify the voices of those individuals, social groups, issues and events rarely seen or heard about in the mainstream media. A glance at the selection of images and lead stories on the home page illustrate the breadth of their reach. There

⁵ <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/stories/uoooyaa-the-brand-clearing-the-made-in-china-label-of-its-bad-rep>



are articles on Kokoroko, an Afrobeat Jazz band; UKTIS, the Skater group of Muslim girls in Britain; and a photo story of a young Afghan girl, Fatima, a refugee aspiring to play world class women's football. Empowering images of black models with vitiligo, plus size models and trans women proudly declare their identity and their individuality. Each story celebrates their mixed cultural heritage, defying the very narrow ideals of traditional white Eurocentric beauty standards.

The key theme of each print magazine directly challenges those dominant ideologies to foreground the underrepresented (#4 'Access' celebrates pioneers pushing boundaries of acceptance; #5 'Defiant Beauty' challenges ethnocentric beauty standards; #6 'Body Movements' challenges inequalities in sports through gender, sexuality, country, etc). The online magazine publishes a selection of these articles, although the unifying theme is not emphasised in the same way on the website.

How and why particular social groups, in a national and global context, may be under-represented or misrepresented.

Most British media companies are still dominated by white male owners, CEOs and employees which does not correspond to the mixed cultural demographics of the British population. Although equal opportunities and positive action policies have impacted on greater inclusivity, it is not equal. In an interview with Creative Review, Rhona Ezuma stated: *'When I started doing my own work I realised that there wasn't the space to tell the sort of stories I was really invested in – stories that would sometimes stem from being someone who grew up in London around so much diversity, and being Black/Nigerian/British and a woman in queer circles, who was coming to understand the multiple ways in which bodies are politicised by representation.'*⁶ THIIIRD magazine exists as a platform to tell those stories and celebrate diversity not in a

tokenistic way, but wholeheartedly.

The processes which lead media producers to make choices about how to represent events, issues, individuals and social groups.

All the representations you find will be different, surprising, pro POC, pro queer, non-binary, existing in a 'third' new transformative space. THIIIRD's representations explicitly celebrate culture, heritage and diversity. Varied social groups are selected for inclusion because they are frequently marginalised by the dominant ideologies of the mainstream. They have experienced inequalities and social and cultural deprivation, largely due to the inherited ideologies of patriarchy and colonialism. In THIIIRD, they are given a space to speak because they have something new and exciting to share.



Image by Vicky Grout / Thiiirdmagazine.co.uk

Caption: Munroe Bergdorf

There are interviews with famous women who have fought their way as pioneers and are now successful in their field. They are not included to attract their fans and sell issues

⁶ Creative Review Good Reads: Thiiird magazine embraces the intersectionality of identity by Aimee McLaughlin 11/06/2021 <https://www.creativereview.co.uk/good-reads-thiiird-magazine/>



or advertising, but are presented as role models, recounting their experiences of how they have overcome discrimination, inspiring others to be resilient and to achieve. We are aligned with them, positioned to view the world from their perspective.

For example, a feature on **Munroe Bergdorf**, interviewed by Rhona Ezuma in 2017, includes a fashion shoot displaying branded clothing. The interview presents her as a social media activist, as a transwoman at a time when prejudice was even more vicious than it is now. The images show Bergdorf from a low angle, a figure to be looked up to. Bergdorf was not as well-known then, and her career since has taken off. One of the ambitions and achievements that THIIIRD is proud of is championing those who are perhaps at the start of their career, giving them a spotlight to help them on their way.

*'Being someone who is unafraid enough to start the conversations that need to be started takes guts, and Munroe Bergdorf certainly has them. She chooses to use her voice not only to make things better for herself and others like her - people who identify as black, trans, queer and/ or womxn - but also for those whose plights are very different from hers, but still face ignorance, discrimination and microaggressions within society. Race, class, gender and ability all affect how we experience the world, and how we are received by it. To a certain extent, the more poor, queer, disabled or coloured you are, the more at a disadvantage you can be in wider society. This is something she wants us to be aware of, in order to make us do better and be better allies.'*⁷

Swimming the Race is the title of an interview with **Rebecca Achieng Ajulu-Bushell**, the first Black woman to swim for Team GB. She has been world number one, Kenyan Sports Personality of the Year, and world school's champion. For Rebecca, the impact of intersectionality is triple.

*'Raised within both Black and white communities, Rebecca was confronted with the dichotomy between her mixed racial identities from an early age. She explains: "In the UK I'm Black, for the most part, then in South Africa I was coloured. In Kenya, kids would be like "Mzungu! Mzungu!" which means white person, and I'd be like 'where? who? Oh, it's me!'"*⁸

The article **'The Personal is Political Project: What is Gender?'** from June 2023 takes advantage of the hyper-modality available to the website and presents a series of short video interviews with a group of 20-somethings. Each 'episode' poses a new question about how they perceive the issue of gender. Their answers encompass their own sense of identity, from gender pronouns to their sexuality, their race, faith and family background, regional and cultural heritage. Each aspect intersects in different ways for each individual. Their answers accumulatively demonstrate that gender is fluid, socially constructed and changes in context. Each episode has been filmed and edited by THIIIRD.⁹



Image by Ciáran Christopher / Thiiirdmagazine.co.uk

Caption: Image from the article 'The Personal is Political Project: What is Gender?'

⁷ Munroe Bergdorf interview by Rhona Ezuma, extract from THIIIRD's print Issue III: Journeys, 2018. [Interview with Munroe Bergdorf](#)

⁸ interview with Rebecca Achieng Ajulu-Bushell, Swimming the Race, THIIIRD Issue #6 p94 2022

⁹ <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/stories/pip-project>



The way in which representations make claims about realism.

Issue 6, 'Body Movements', is published in partnership with the **NIKE LONDON GRANT INITIATIVE**, a project that specifically aims to assist Black people challenge racism by funding projects that promote health and well-being, arts and culture, education and sports. Several articles promote the work being done by charities who have benefited from this 2021 project: *Just Doing It*, *Black Companies Making Change*. They feature ordinary people in ordinary places, in areas of London that are particularly socially deprived, such as the Dwaynatics Boxing Club in Brixton, the Peckham Theatre project and the Baytree Centre for girls.

One article promotes the **S.M.I.L.E-ing Boys Project**, which aims to change negative stereotypical media images of young Black men through art. The boys are interviewed as named individuals, photographed in their everyday environment, the effect of which is to humanise them, make us feel closer and identify with them. The aim of the project is *'to empower young Black boys by providing tangible coping strategies to manage their mental health, through workshops, activities and field trips.'*¹⁰



Image by @ejatushaw / Thiiirdmagazine.co.uk
Caption: The S.M.I.L.E-ing Boys Project

Theoretical perspectives

Theories of representation – Stuart Hall

THIIIRD magazine goes against stereotyping as its project is to counter ideas of 'otherness' and present 'togetherness.' Because of inequalities of power, THIIIRD amplifies those groups who have been 'othered' previously. In a collective embrace, it invites us to share as a community, to identify and feel empathy, by understanding other peoples' perspective; not othering them but seeing everyone as part of our community.

Theories of identity – David Gauntlett

THIIIRD celebrates diversity through culture and heritage, race and gender. The podcast often starts with the group of THIIIRD presenters, describing their individual identities, so the audience can place how they may identify with them. Look for your own examples from the magazine website to explore how THIIIRD offers a more diverse range of icons and characters from whom we can 'pick and mix' aspects of our identity. You could use these examples as a basis to practice the type of exam question that asks you how far you can apply the theory here to evaluate Gauntlett's theory.

Feminist theory – bell hooks

Although bell hooks' feminist theory is not one of the set theorists for this set product, it is a valuable text to explore the critical idea of intersectionality: the idea that race and class, as well as sex, determine the extent to which individuals are discriminated against or oppressed. THIIIRD defines itself as an intersectional feminist magazine, embracing all those unheard voices that have been marginalised by the hegemonic ideologies of the group in dominant power positions. Instead, THIIIRD reclaims and celebrates that third space where the discourse of many cultures, languages and heritages intersect.

¹⁰ THIIIRD Instagram 12.11.2022



The ethos of THIIIRD is informed by decolonial and intersectional feminist thought. We believe in the potential of print and multimedia as a tool for (self-) affirmation and positive social change.’¹¹

Theories around ethnicity and postcolonial theory – Paul Gilroy

THIIIRD is informed by decolonial thought, developing Gilroy’s idea that colonial discourses still inform contemporary attitudes to race and ethnicity. THIIIRD embraces the 21st century idea of decolonisation, that there are many kinds of diasporic identities, all of which are valid and worthy of respect. Decolonising means unravelling the idea that there is only one ‘correct’ ethnocentric truth, recognising there are many lenses to look through. Instead of accepting a very narrow ‘traditional’ ideal of beauty or culture, decolonisation encourages us to pay attention to all the threads of heritage that form a narrative of our shared culture and past, all different. This democratisation of worth goes against the idea of civilisationism, where *‘identity is as much about difference as about shared belonging.’*¹² Decolonising our past allows us to hear a much more clamorous, chaotic, hybrid collection of all sorts of people who are welcomed into the group to have their say. You could compare this with other set products that discuss decolonialism, for example, **Have You Heard George’s Podcast?**

PART 3 STARTING POINTS: Media industries

Processes of production, distribution and circulation by organisations, groups and individuals in a global context.

As a small independent magazine, THIIIRD’s editorial team have to find their own funding for each issue of the magazine through a range of methods. Initially, Rhona and a partner invested their own savings to create

the first print issue. When they managed to successfully launch the magazine and recoup their money, they reinvested it for the next issue. The web magazine draws attention to the annual print edition, promotes THIIIRD’s events and podcast, and encourages the community of creatives and readers to buy the print magazine, and to contribute to it.

‘Print is definitely the holy grail, but the other channels we use are our podcast, social media, our online website and, in the regular world, events.’¹³

Although the print magazine is expensive to produce, the web magazine also carries a lot of costs, in terms of labour and office space, updating the website with current material, managing responses to questions, ideas for submissions and orders from the shop. 3000 editions are printed for each issue, and several have sold out. The magazine is available in stockists throughout the world, especially popular in New York and Amsterdam. Online outlets, such as Stack and magCulture, also sell the magazine and in this way publicise THIIIRD’s website. The print magazine is distributed by an established independent distribution company in Falmouth, Ra and Olly, who have been distributing indie magazines all over the world since Time Out in 1969.

Representations in the magazine reflect the people who own and run the magazine. Rhona Ezuma is editor-in-chief and she states on Instagram:

‘Our magazine is women-run and Black owned with an eclectic diverse team of creatives. We are making sure the voices of people of colour, trans, non-binary, queer individuals, women and all marginalised peoples are platformed on our space.’¹⁴

¹¹ THIIIRD manifesto <https://www.thiiirdmagazine.co.uk/about>

¹² Gilroy, 1993

¹³ <https://magculture.com/blogs/journal/rhona-thiiird>

¹⁴ THIIIRD Instagram post 11.4.2023



A review based on the ONS Labour Force Survey of 2021, published by the NCTJ, found that the number of non-white journalists was still disproportionate with the UK population. *'There is still a greater proportion of white journalists (92%) than the workforce as a whole (88%).'*¹⁵ In order to counter this imbalance, Rhona and her team actively work with BIPOC and gender queer as employees and in their editorial content.

The significance of economic factors, including commercial and not-for-profit public funding, to media industries and their products.

The 2018 Somerset House Print exhibition **Tearing it Up** was a celebration of flourishing independent magazine publishing in Britain, past and present, at a time when mainstream magazines sales dwindled. This exhibition defined independence as *'putting Ideas before profit'*, and THIIIRD as a new magazine participated. Such arts platforms are key to getting industry attention from cultural opinion leaders.

THIIIRD is an independent magazine with no direct advertising, and though this may change in future, its primary goal is not to sell the demographics of the core reader profile to get advertising revenue. It is a fashion magazine that is more of a cultural enterprise than a commercial/consumerist one, but it still needs money to exist. Rhona and her team have to be more resourceful in getting funding and have to devote time and labour to develop income streams. As an independent company, they may be eligible to benefit from cultural grants; in the past, they have received investments from local business grants and the Prince's Trust.

Rhona Ezuma's work as a stylist for mainstream brands, such as Adidas, and magazines, like Vogue and GQ, could lead to making connections with media buyers from various brands to develop new partnerships.

The fashion shoots displaying branded clothing are not affiliated or paid for, but when THIIIRD receives a commission, the editorial team are able to pay themselves a little. There is a link on the About Us page to encourage brands to get in contact for partnerships.

In 2022, the **Nike London Grant Initiative** commissioned THIIIRD to promote the ways their donations were being put to good use. Both print and web magazines were given separate fees for the advertorial content that publicised the good work the different local charities were doing for their communities, such as the S.M.I.L.E-ing Boys Project. The print issue had an extra pull out, an inside front cover gatefold, to highlight the NIKE project.

The impact of digitally convergent platforms on media production, distribution and circulation.

There is no paywall for the web magazine, so the reader can explore, visit the shop and buy back issues there as well. As of October 2023, the web magazine has about 1.9K readers per month. Social media is used to publicise new articles and news about events, drawing followers back to the magazine hub. There is a direct link to *'our IG'* on the magazine's About page. THIIIRD has nearly 6,000 Instagram followers (as of October 2023), and there are several posts a week to engage with their community, including to get involved with the production of the 7th issue of the magazine.

As a result of the pandemic, one of the international distributors THIIIRD used for online sales of the print magazine went under, and any upfront payments were lost due to the distributor's bankruptcy. THIIIRD lost money, and the future of the magazine was in jeopardy. A Crowdfunder page was set up for Issue #5, to encourage followers to invest in the print magazine

¹⁵ 13.5 2021 <https://pressgazette.co.uk/news/nctj-diversity-journalism-number-journalists/>



before publication. The Defiant Beauty issue has now sold out. In an interview with magCulture, Rhona admitted:

*'We've had to work smart and reach out to our community and readers, which we did through a fundraiser that saw us raise 3k on pre-orders of the issue, so I am feeling the most sanguine I have in about a year.'*¹⁶

THIIIRD Intersect Events, such as **Not Another Diversity Panel** at Tate Modern or **Reclaiming the Narrative Panel** at The Photographer's Gallery, provide further platforms to draw attention to the magazine, sell the current issue in their bookshops and to invite the community to join the event. The web magazine and social media publicise these events, for example in Summer 2023, the Swim N' Cook Out or the Sports Days events in combination with Black Pride and Issue #6 'BODY MOVEMENTS'.

Theoretical perspective

Cultural Industries – David Hesmondhalgh

Hesmondhalgh states large cultural industry companies try to minimise risk and maximise audiences through vertical and horizontal integration by formatting their cultural products. As an independent magazine, owned and run by a small team of passionate creatives, THIIIRD is the opposite. It doesn't follow a formula or repeat a set of genre conventions; it celebrates diversity, difference and disparate voices. It doesn't have the massive financial backing of a large conglomerate, and it doesn't seek to increase profits through advertising revenue. You could argue that in the past, mainstream consumerist magazine publishers exaggerated the opposites of binary gender characteristics to 'foster and maintain a cult of femininity'¹⁷ (or masculinity) for commercial gain. They wanted to persuade their readers to buy the products advertised in the magazine to belong, to be a better

'man' or better 'woman' (however the magazine constructed them). As an activist fashion magazine, THIIIRD deliberately steps over those boundaries into a third, different, 'queer' space of more complex, individual identities, thus embracing another, perhaps more relevant, 'shared belonging'¹⁸, for all of us. Hesmondhalgh states advertising encroaches upon every aspect of our online experience, yet there is little advertising in THIIIRD. Of course, they are always looking for partnerships to help finance their operation, there is some advertorial content, and more advertising may feature in future. However, it is a risky business for THIIIRD, who invest their time, creativity and personal savings because they believe in THIIIRD as a cultural hub for people to come together and bring about positive social change.

THIIIRD illustrates Hesmondhalgh's idea of democratisation and the radical potential of the internet. Rhona and her team saw a gap in the market for people like themselves, and so set up their own media forms. But it has not '*been contained to some extent by its partial incorporation into a large, profit-orientated set of cultural industries.*'¹⁹ They may collaborate with a major brand on a social project, or a fashion label on a niche line, but they need to be resourceful, seeking opportunities and responding when the contracts are offered. They may work in synergy with partners to collaborate with other independent media forms or with traditional cultural institutions, such as art galleries. As a cultural hub, they must be agile and alert to communicate what is happening at the time. You could argue that the THIIIRD team are examples of Hesmondhalgh's 'digital optimists'.

¹⁶ <https://magculture.com/blogs/journal/rhona-thiiird>

¹⁷ Marjorie Ferguson, *Forever Feminine: Women's Magazines and the Cult of Femininity* (1985)

¹⁸ Gilroy's term
¹⁹ David Hesmondhalgh, *The Cultural Industries*, (2012), p.2



PART 4 STARTING POINTS: Media audiences

How audiences are grouped and categorised by media industries, including by age, gender and social class, as well as by lifestyle and taste.

Mainstream magazines categorise the core buyer profile of their audiences precisely to package their demographic 'data' and deliver them to advertisers to make money. As THIIIRD is independent and does not rely on advertising for profit, the audiences they are targeting are much more loosely defined, a collection of diverse niche audiences.

When asked who constitutes the audience of THIIIRD, Rhona responded:

*'What we care about is very people of colour centred, very women-led and queer, so naturally, we find people who identify in these ways are a huge part of our audience... Another is anyone who loves music, art, fashion and photography, and cares about making society better for those communities.'*²⁰

How media producers target, attract, reach, address and potentially construct audiences.

THIIIRD immediately engages audiences through its striking aesthetic: a colourful and sophisticated layout and design style that showcases its subjects and content through arresting and beautifully composed photographic images of unusual, intriguing subjects. The subjects of the photographs draw your attention to a collection of interesting people, gathered together in one community. It is intriguing and educational; in that you can find out about other cultures and their heritage as well as identify with aspects of your own. THIIIRD addresses and constructs their audience as a community of like-minded people, interested in art, culture, fashion and heritage and who want to bring about social change to enhance equality.

The language of the About Us page is direct, confident and assertive, conveying a clear sense of vision of what the magazine stands for. Elsewhere, the mode of address is friendly, informal and uses the colloquial language of its community, making the reader feel part of the group, with images of the editorial team to emphasise that connection.

On Instagram, there is a short clip of the production team sitting around a table, and the camera cuts between them giving the impression that we are a part of the circle, joining in the conversation.

How media industries target audiences through the content and appeal of a media products and through the ways in which they are marketed, distributed and circulated.

Part of its appeal is there isn't anything else like it. It is true that THIIIRD was inspired by gal-dem magazine, and the refreshing way gal-dem spoke to its young Black female audience, but THIIIRD engages a much wider group of readers from all different backgrounds and heritages.

*'Traditional outlets may have woken up to the demand there is to champion new styles of beauty, but they are still heavily packaged, because they still on some level are about pleasing dominant western standards.'*²¹

How audiences interact with the media and can be actively involved in media production.

The website facilitates interaction and positively encourages readers to participate. There are straightforward options buttons to Contact us, either to say hi, ask a question or to suggest an idea. There is another button to send ideas for submissions, and that gives more clear, formal information about how to format your pitch for your idea.

²⁰ <https://www.upmpaper.com>

²¹ Rhona Ezuma interview
<https://magculture.com/blogs/journal/rhona-thiird>



The link to their Instagram account keeps you up to date with cultural events. THIIIRD acts as a hub to keep their audience in the loop, informing them about the type of events they may be interested in supporting.

In September 2023, there was a direct appeal to the audience, calling on interested individuals to get involved professionally, to work for the magazine or help contribute to the latest issue by sending examples of work. This shows that the THIIIRD community also exists to nurture opportunities for emerging young talent, who may otherwise find it hard to get a foot in the door.

How specialised audiences can be reached, both on a national and global scale, through different media technologies and platforms.

While most THIIIRD events and the magazine itself are based in London, the most multicultural city in the UK, the print magazine is distributed across 3 continents and over 20 countries, and the website can be accessed globally. Articles like **Skater UKTIS** draw attention to the international club that exists across 26 countries, prioritising well-being, sport and faith. It has a broad international appeal, and could inspire other Muslim women to join, or to create a similar article to share with the THIIIRD community. **Not Just Brown, Not Just Indian: South Asian Women of the Diaspora** is a photographic project where the women from six different countries demonstrate and explain their divergent cultures and traditions – they are not just lumped together as 'Indian'. Both subjects have a broad global appeal, both in the UK and internationally.

The THIIIRD Waves podcast was originally broadcast twice a month on London's Soho Radio, so connected with the 400,000 local and global listeners there. THIIIRD now produce their own standalone podcast, available on all of the usual podcast platforms, so it potentially has a global reach. The subjects covered may differ from the

magazine content and cover more topical issues of the day, such as toxic masculinity, neurodiversity or cancel culture.

THIIIRD Waves' partnership with **FOUNDATION FM** in 2019 was another way of collaborating with like-minded people for similar audiences, to get people talking about both forms. FOUNDATION FM is an all-female radio station based in South London, and THIIIRD Waves' takeover for **Brunch with Kamilla** enabled another niche radio audience to connect and find out about the THIIIRD community. Kamilla Rose and THIIIRD Waves produced four episodes together.

How audiences use media in different ways, reflecting demographic factors as well as aspects of identity and cultural capital.

Another common characteristic that THIIIRD and FOUNDATION FM share is that, as young women of colour who may have felt marginalised by the media they liked, they didn't find a message that chimed with their reality, so they created their own. They made something different, that may be very niche, independent, and made for love rather than money, but it's their artform to express their identity, and connect with others like them. The accessibility of digital technology facilitates this DIY culture to 'just do it.'

THIIIRD is still a new magazine that continues to build and make connections with new audiences and creative people with something different to say. They hope to shape the world in a different way. Rhona is very clear in her ambition for THIIIRD to champion new talent, to enlighten and empower ambitious creatives who want to develop their career in the media. THIIIRD is a cultural hub for their community, for social interaction and for getting people involved. So, you can contribute, too!



Theoretical perspectives

'End of audience' theories – Clay Shirky

Shirky argues that digital technologies have had a profound effect on the relationship between media and audience members, who are no longer passively accepting their message. THIRRD actively invites audiences to get involved, participate and interact. They do not just invite you to speak back but also submit ideas for submissions, attend events and join in, or go and work for the magazine. THIRRD is a hub for dynamic interaction, a conversation about culture that allows us to discuss things through another lens.

Cultivation theory – George Gerbner

Gerbner argues that exposure to the same repeated patterns of representation reinforce the values of the dominant ideology and influence the way people think. THIRRD's intention is to question that perspective, to foreground the underrepresented and look at things through a different lens. You could argue that by thinking about the issues raised by the magazine and engaging with its content, audiences could become more aware of inequalities in our society. For example, they may become more attuned to the social and cultural impact of the issues surrounding diversity and inclusivity in mainstream fashion magazines and their very narrow definitions of what is perceived as beautiful or desirable.